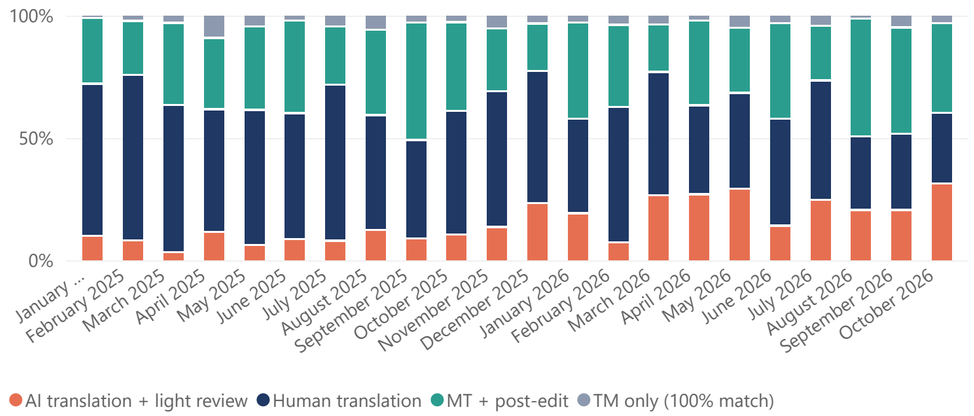
AI vs traditional translation: localization operations

Simulated data for a fictional company, Jan 2025 to Oct 2026. Not real company data.

Words	Cost (CAD)	Cost Per Word	AI Assisted Share	On time	Avg LQA Score
Total words	Total cost	Cost per word	AI-assisted share of words	On-time %	Avg LQA score
5M	$739K	0.136	48.33%	0.81	93.90

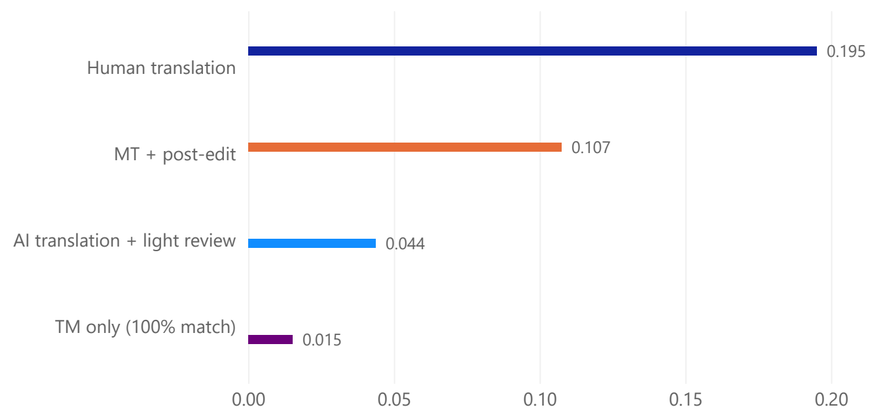
Share of words by workflow

Total words by Month start and Workflow



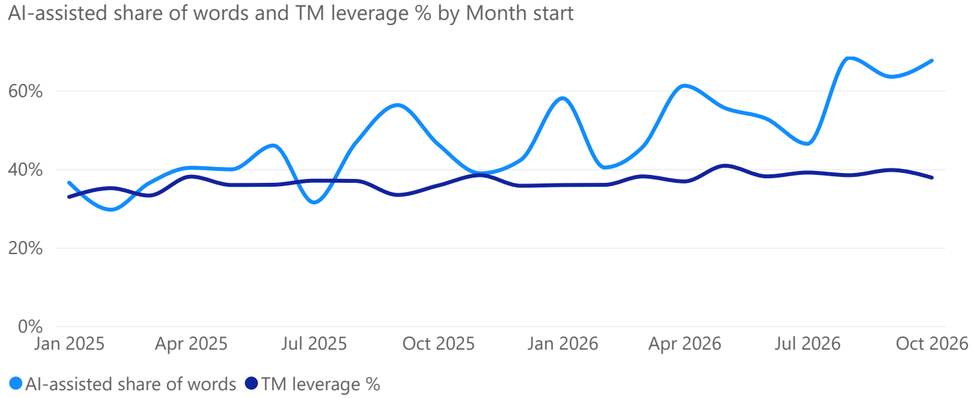
Cost per word by workflow (CAD)

Cost per word, Total words and Total cost by Workflow and Workflow



AI-assisted share and TM reuse by month.

AI-assisted share of words and TM leverage % by Month start



What the data shows

- AI adoption is rising: machine- or AI-first workflows handled 41.0% of words in 2025 and 55.9% in 2026 (January to October).
- It's cutting cost: average cost per word fell 16%, from $0.147 to $0.124. AI with light review costs $0.044 a word, against $0.195 for human translation.
- Translation memory reuse grew from 35.6% to 38.0% of words, adding to the savings.

Date

1/1/2025 — 12/31/2026

Region

All

Business function

All

Target language

All

Definitions on Notes Page

Effort, quality and vendors

Simulated data for a fictional company, Jan 2025 to Oct 2026. Not real company data.

Edit Ratio by Language and Quarter

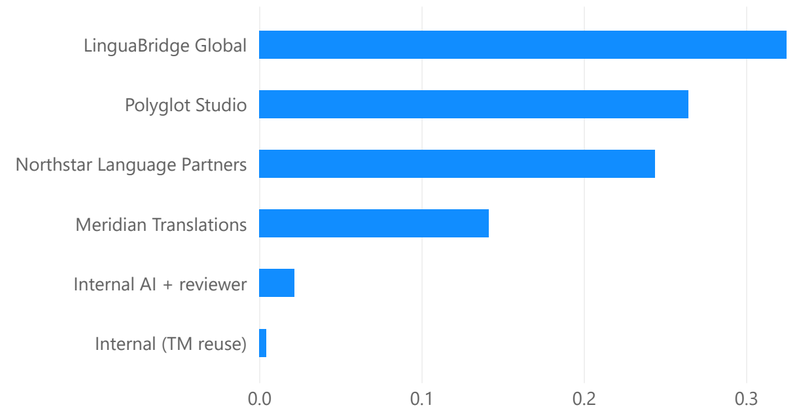
Target language	2025 Q1	2025 Q2	2025 Q3	2025 Q4	2026 Q1	2026 Q2	2026 Q3	2026 Q4
Chinese (Simplified)	0.28	0.24	0.22	0.21	0.21	0.19	0.20	0.10
Chinese (Traditional)	0.24	0.19	0.25	0.23	0.20	0.17	0.19	0.20
Dutch	0.22	0.23	0.11	0.13	0.16	0.12	0.09	0.10
French (Canada)	0.17	0.16	0.14	0.14	0.12	0.12	0.12	0.12
French (France)	0.15	0.18	0.16	0.17	0.16	0.09	0.12	0.11
German	0.17	0.17	0.18	0.20	0.13	0.09	0.12	0.08
Italian	0.17	0.19	0.18	0.12	0.15	0.09	0.12	0.11
Japanese	0.29	0.27	0.28	0.25	0.24	0.23	0.23	0.19
Korean	0.31	0.31	0.29	0.23	0.26	0.21	0.23	0.20
Spanish (Mexico)	0.15	0.13	0.19	0.15	0.11	0.11	0.11	0.10
Spanish (Spain)	0.15	0.19	0.09	0.10	0.17	0.18	0.11	0.04
Swedish	0.22	0.19	0.13	0.16	0.09	0.13	0.07	0.19
Thai			0.35	0.26	0.34	0.27	0.19	0.20

Turnaround and effort by workflow

Workflow	Jobs	Avg turnaround days	On-time %	Words per linguist hour
TM only (100% match)	242	1.22	0.81	4,472.90
AI translation + light review	431	1.61	0.83	1,593.95
MT + post-edit	777	2.53	0.84	728.10
Human translation	1119	4.20	0.78	387.42
Total	**2569**	**2.98**	**0.81**	**559.52**

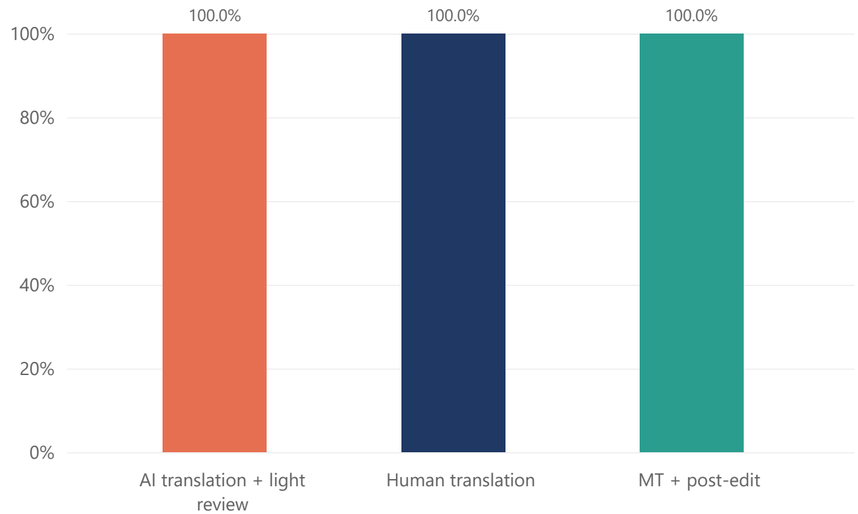
Share of spend by vendor

Vendor share of spend, Total cost and Jobs by Vendor



LQA pass rate by Workflow

LQA pass rate by Workflow



Date

1/1/2025 — 12/31/2026

Region

All

Business function

All

Target language

All

Workflow

All

LQA pass threshold

70

Definitions on Notes Page

Delivery Root Cause

Simulated data for a fictional company, Jan 2025 to Oct 2026. Not real company data.

Date

1/1/2025 — 12/31/2026

Region: All

Business function: All

Target language: All

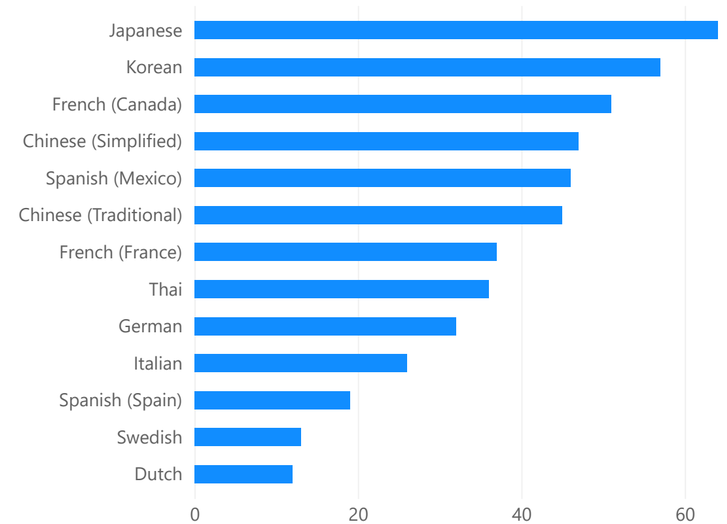
Definitions on Notes Page

On-time % by language and vendor (cells with 10+ jobs)

Target language	Internal (TM reuse)	Internal AI + reviewer	LinguaBridge Global	Meridian Translations	Northstar Language Partners	Polyglot Studio	**Total**
Chinese (Simplified)	0.83	0.64	0.81		0.83	0.81	**0.80**
Chinese (Traditional)	0.69		0.76			0.69	**0.73**
Dutch			0.94		0.87		**0.87**
French (Canada)	0.86	0.95	0.85	0.83	0.86		**0.86**
French (France)	0.96	0.88	0.72	0.91	0.82		**0.82**
German	0.75	0.82	0.83	0.88	0.91		**0.86**
Italian	0.83	0.91	0.68	0.85	0.84		**0.81**
Japanese	0.72	0.64	0.75		0.67	0.81	**0.76**
Korean	0.73	0.82	0.78		0.71	0.79	**0.78**
Spanish (Mexico)	0.95	0.77	0.81	0.83	0.83		**0.83**
Spanish (Spain)	0.87	0.92	0.90	0.84	0.89		**0.87**
Swedish			0.86		0.82		**0.82**
Thai	0.85		0.77			0.72	**0.71**
Total	**0.81**	**0.82**	**0.80**	**0.84**	**0.84**	**0.77**	**0.81**

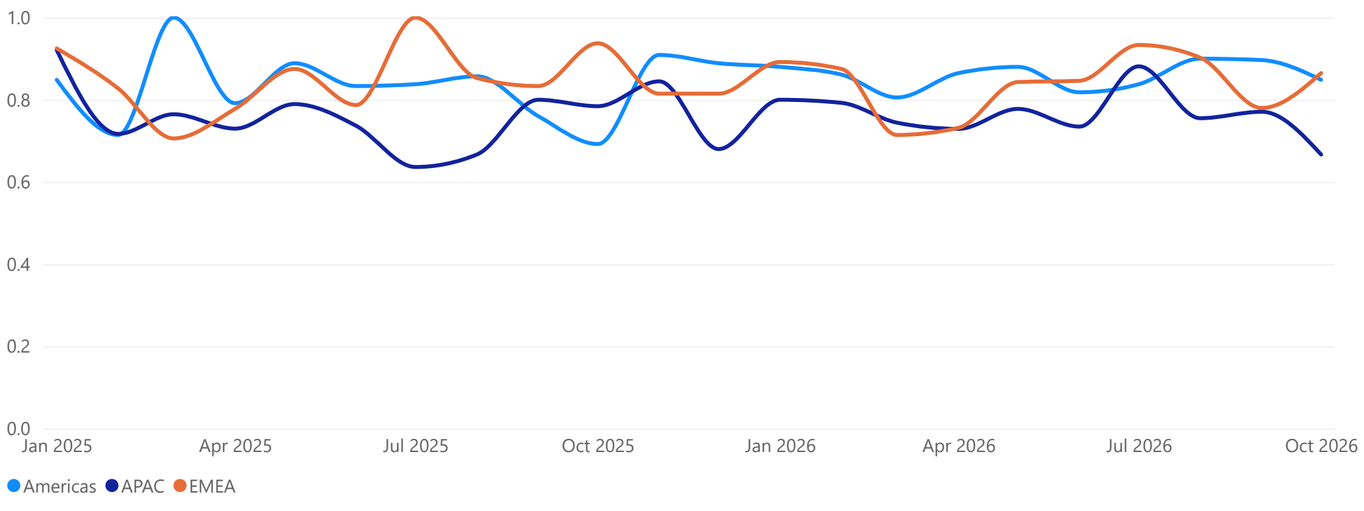
Late jobs by Language

Late jobs, Avg days late, On-time % and Jobs by Target language



On-time % by region, by month

On-time % by Month start and Region



Root Cause and corrective action

- **Finding:** APAC jobs are on time 76.2% of the time, against 84.5% in the Americas and EMEA. Thai was worst in its first three months: 42.9% on time (July to September 2025, 21 jobs), against 76.9% afterwards.
- **Likely cause:** language and market, not vendor. Within APAC, every vendor sits between 67% and 77% on time. Polyglot Studio looks weakest overall (77.4%) only because most of its work is APAC.
- **Corrective action:** set APAC due dates that reflect the extra editing (23.8% post-edit distance, against about 14% elsewhere). For new markets, use a launch checklist that seeds the glossary and translation memory before go-live, with longer due dates for the first 90 days.
- **How we'd measure it:** APAC on-time % by quarter, and on-time % in the next new language's first three months

Notes

Definitions:

- **Cost per word:** invoiced cost divided by source words.
- **AI-assisted share of words:** share of words translated by machine translation or AI first, then reviewed.
- **TM leverage %:** share of words fully or partly matched in translation memory.
- **Edit ratio (post-edit distance):** share of machine or AI output the reviewer changed, weighted by words. Lower means better machine output.
- **On-time % (SLA adherence):** share of jobs delivered on or before the due date.
- **Turnaround days:** calendar days from request to delivery.
- **LQA pass rate:** share of quality-reviewed jobs scoring at or above the threshold. About 35% of non-TM jobs are reviewed.
- **Vendor share of spend:** a vendor's cost as a share of all vendors' cost, within the current filters.
- **Late jobs:** jobs delivered after their due date.
- **Avg days late:** average days past the due date, for late jobs only.
- **On-time % (10+ jobs):** on-time %, shown only where at least 10 jobs sit behind it.